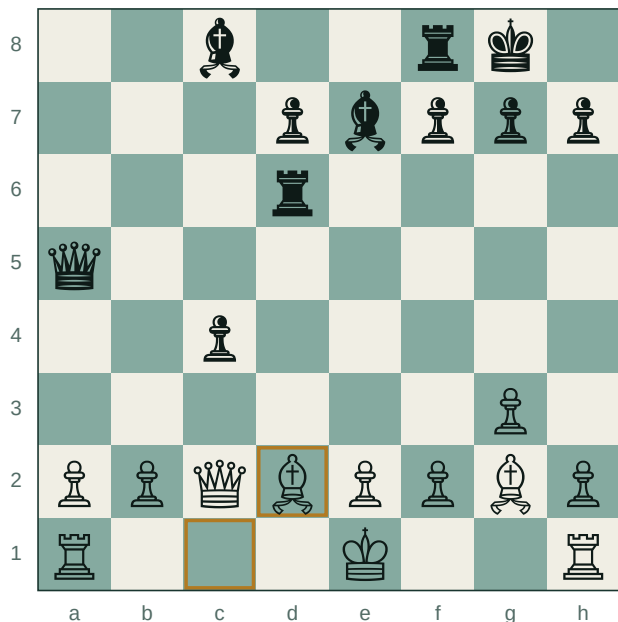


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 16

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 16.Bd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Rxd2 17. Qxd2 Bb4 18. Qxb4 Qxb4+

16...Rxd2 The rook captures the bishop on d2. Recorded reply: **17.Qxd2**.

17...Bb4 The bishop moves from e7 to b4. Recorded reply: **18.Qxb4**.

18...Qxb4+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the queen on b4.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on e1. Absolute pin: bishop on d2.